AURORA FORGE / VIKINGSTUDIOS

WWE 2K26

PC MODDING HANDBOOK

Reader-First Edition

Start safely. Change one thing. Test it. Know how to undo it.

Installing Mods / Textures / Attires / Characters / Audio / GFX / Arenas / Belts / Ports

Built for Aurora Forge v1.6.0.d

Independent community handbook - not an official 2K or tool-vendor manual

Welcome

This book is for readers who want to complete a modding task, not study the history of how that task was researched. Start with the smallest job that meets your goal. Finish it. Test it. Keep the working copy.

> **THE RULE THAT PROTECTS EVERYTHING:** Never work on the only copy. Every chapter assumes you have a backup and a known-good build.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

- New to modding: complete Parts 1 and 2 in order.
- Changing artwork only: continue to Part 3.
- Adding clothing or hair: continue to Part 4.
- Building a full file-level character: complete Parts 1 through 5.
- Adding music, announcer audio, or entrance media: use Part 6.
- Working on arenas or championship belts: use Part 7.
- Moving content from WWE 2K25: complete the advanced Part 8.
- Something is broken: jump to Part 9 and start with the symptom you can see.

WHAT AURORA FORGE DOES

Aurora Forge plans assets, keeps references together, prepares handoff packs, and helps you validate changes. Specialist programs still perform game-file operations such as baking, slot registration, model work, audio import, and arena placement.

> **DO NOT FORCE ONE TOOL TO DO EVERY JOB:** Use Aurora Forge for planning and validation. Use CakeView/CakeHook, Tribute, Blender/PWM, Quick Port, a DDS tool, an audio tool, or Arena Builder only for the jobs they own.

Choose the lowest-risk path

Your goal	Start here	Typical risk
Install a finished mod	Part 2	Low to medium
Change a texture, face, tattoo, mask, or logo	Part 3	Medium
Add or edit an attire, hair, or accessory	Part 4	High
Build a complete file-level character	Part 5	Very high
Add music, announcer audio, or GFX	Part 6	Medium to high
Install or create an arena or belt	Part 7	Medium to high
Port 2K25 content into 2K26	Part 8	Advanced / very high

Contents

Use the PDF bookmarks or Word Navigation pane to jump directly to a part or chapter.

PART 1

Start Safely

Set up a recoverable workspace before touching game files.

1. Build Your Modding Folders

BEGINNER	Create one predictable place for tools, projects, downloads, backups, and documentation.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Close the game.
- Choose a drive with enough free space for several test builds.
- Do not use the game folder as your normal workspace.

STEPS

1. Create a main folder named WWE2K26_Modding.
2. Inside it, create Apps, Projects, Downloads_Quarantine, Tool_Archives, and Documentation.
3. Inside Projects, create one folder for the project you are about to start.
4. Keep paid or proprietary applications in Apps, but never bundle them inside a public mod package.
5. Place new downloads in Downloads_Quarantine until you have read the source page and scanned the archive.
6. Keep the previous working version of each tool in Tool_Archives until the new version passes a test.

EXPECTED RESULT: Your tools, source files, working files, and game installation are now separated.

STOP IF: Stop if the project is being created inside the WWE 2K26 installation folder or you cannot tell which files are tools and which files are game assets.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Delete only the empty folder structure and start again in a safer location.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Using Downloads as a permanent workspace.
- Overwriting an older tool version before the new one is tested.
- Mixing multiple characters or arenas in one working folder.

NEXT: Make backups that can be restored, not just copied somewhere at random.

2. Make Backups You Can Actually Restore

BEGINNER	Create an untouched original, numbered test builds, and a simple rollback path.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have completed Chapter 1.
- The game launches normally before any new change.
- You know which folders the current project will touch.

STEPS

1. Inside the project folder, create 00_source_notes, 01_original_extracted_READ_ONLY, 02_aurora_handoff, 03_working_textures, 04_working_models, 05_working_audio_video, 06_bakeme_staging, 07_test_builds, 08_release, and 09_screenshots_and_logs.
2. Copy the untouched source package into 01_original_extracted_READ_ONLY.
3. Mark that folder read-only when practical. Never edit files inside it.
4. Before every meaningful change, duplicate the last working build into a new numbered folder such as Test_001, Test_002, and Test_003.
5. Write one sentence in 00_source_notes explaining what changed in each test build.
6. After a successful in-game test, mark that build LAST_KNOWN_GOOD.
7. Before a game or tool update, preserve the current loader files, Tribute data, and active mod staging folders.

EXPECTED RESULT: You can identify the untouched source, the current experiment, and the last working build without guessing.

STOP IF: Stop if the only copy of a file is open in an editor, Blender, Tribute, CakeView, or the game folder.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the LAST_KNOWN_GOOD folder and remove only the files introduced by the failed test.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- A backup exists but nobody knows what version it contains.
- All test builds have the same filename.
- The original package has been edited accidentally.

NEXT: Connect only the tools required for your chosen path.

3. Connect the Required Tools

BEGINNER	Configure Aurora Forge and verify the external programs you will actually use.

VERSION-SENSITIVE: Tool screens and menu names can move after updates. Record the game and tool versions used by every successful build.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Download tools only from their current trusted source.
- Keep account names, license details, and activation data private.
- Install each tool according to its vendor instructions.

STEPS

1. Open Aurora Forge Setup.
2. Select the WWE 2K26 game directory.
3. Select CakeView.
4. Select Tribute only when the project needs slots, attires, music, announcer data, or related registration.
5. Select Blender and the supported PWM addon only when the project changes geometry, skeletons, weights, hair, or accessories.
6. Select Quick Port only as an assistant to the supported Blender/PWM workflow.
7. Select texconv or another verified DDS-capable program.
8. Select the Projects and Exports folders created in Chapter 1.
9. Run the read-only checks and save the settings.
10. Treat an optional missing tool as not configured, not as a failed installation.

EXPECTED RESULT: Aurora Forge can find the game and every tool needed for the current project.

STOP IF: Stop if Aurora Forge points to an old tool version, a different game, or a personal temporary folder.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous Aurora Forge settings or clear the incorrect path and choose it again.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Connecting every installed tool even though the project does not need them.
- Using an unofficial mirror for paid tools.
- Assuming Quick Port replaces Blender or the PWM addon.

NEXT: Prove that the clean game and loader work before adding a real mod.

4. Run the Clean Baseline Test

BEGINNER	Prove that the unmodified game and basic loader setup work before testing a project.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- No new mod is enabled.
- The original game files are intact.
- You have backed up any existing loader files.

STEPS

1. Launch WWE 2K26 without custom mods enabled.
2. Open a normal match and confirm the game reaches gameplay.
3. Close the game normally.
4. Install or update CakeHook exactly as its current vendor instructions require.
5. Launch the game again with CakeHook present but no custom project enabled.
6. Confirm the game still reaches a normal match.
7. Open CakeView and confirm the correct WWE 2K26 executable and target are selected.
8. Save a screenshot or text note naming the game version, CakeHook version, and CakeView version.

EXPECTED RESULT: The clean game works, then the game also works with the loader installed and no custom mod active.

STOP IF: Stop if the game fails before any project is enabled. Do not troubleshoot a mod until the clean baseline works.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Remove only the newly added loader files, restore the previous loader backup, and repeat the clean-game test.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Testing a large character pack as the first loader test.
- Leaving old loader files mixed with a new version.
- Assuming a successful desktop launch proves matches and entrances work.

NEXT: Use the same create, inspect, bake, test, and restore loop for every project.

5. Understand the Aurora Forge Project Loop

BEGINNER Use one repeatable workflow for every texture, attire, character, arena, or port.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The baseline test passes.
- You have a project folder and an untouched source copy.
- You know the smallest change that meets your goal.

STEPS

1. Create the project in Aurora Forge and save it immediately.
2. Add only useful reference images and source files.
3. Choose one source of truth for dimensions, layout, geometry, or material behavior.
4. Use the matching Aurora Forge studio to prepare the brief and handoff pack.
5. Work on copies inside the project folder.
6. Inspect the original and modified folders before baking.
7. Bake one small change.
8. Test the exact feature changed.
9. Keep the build only when the test passes.
10. Make the next change from the last known-good build.

EXPECTED RESULT: Every change has a source, a working copy, a test build, an in-game result, and a rollback point.

STOP IF: Stop when two source authorities disagree, the modified folder contains unexpected files, or you cannot explain every change in the next bake.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Return to the last known-good build and repeat the loop with a smaller change.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Generating an asset before choosing its real target profile.
- Treating a concept sheet as a game-ready texture.
- Changing a model, materials, textures, music, and GFX in one test.

NEXT: Install one ready-made mod and complete your first full test loop.

PART 2

Your First Working Mod

Complete one safe, visible project before moving into creation or porting.

6. Install One Ready-Made Mod

BEGINNER	Bake and test one creator-approved package without changing its contents.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The clean baseline test passes.
- The mod is intended for WWE 2K26 and your current tool setup.
- You have read the package README from beginning to end.
- You have backed up the active game-side and staging data.

STEPS

1. Scan the downloaded archive before extracting it.
2. Extract it into a new project folder, not directly into the game folder.
3. Read the author instructions and identify every folder that must be baked or copied.
4. Open CakeView and confirm the WWE 2K26 game path and target.
5. Choose New Bake.
6. Select only the staging folder named by the package author.
7. Check the target and output before pressing Bake.
8. Wait for the success result and save the bake log.
9. Repeat only when the package instructions name another folder.
10. Launch the game and test the exact wrestler, attire, arena, belt, or feature changed by the mod.

EXPECTED RESULT: The specific feature named by the package appears in game and the unrelated baseline still works.

STOP IF: Stop if the archive does not include instructions, names a different game version, asks you to overwrite unknown originals, or contains files you cannot explain.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Remove the newly baked or copied project files and restore the backups created before installation.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Baking the outer download folder instead of the actual staging folder.
- Baking both a finished CAK path and a loose-folder path when the author intended only one.
- Testing a different feature and concluding the mod works.

NEXT: Confirm the mod, record the result, and practice removing it safely.

7. Confirm It Loaded and Remove It Safely

BEGINNER	Prove the mod changed only what it was supposed to change, then restore the clean state.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Chapter 6 completed without a crash.
- You saved the bake log and know which files were added.
- You still have the pre-install backup.

STEPS

1. Launch the same match, menu, entrance, or scene used for the baseline test.
2. Confirm the intended change appears.
3. Check one unrelated wrestler or arena to make sure the installation did not have a broad side effect.
4. Take an in-game screenshot and store it in 09_screenshots_and_logs.
5. Write the game version, tool versions, package name, and result in the project notes.
6. Close the game.
7. Remove only the files introduced by the mod or restore the exact pre-install staging backup.
8. Launch the same test again.
9. Confirm the clean result has returned.

EXPECTED RESULT: You have demonstrated both installation and rollback. The same test can be repeated later.

STOP IF: Stop if you cannot tell which files belong to the mod. Restore the full known-good backup instead of deleting files by guesswork.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the complete pre-install game-side and staging backup.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Deleting shared files used by another mod.
- Removing the source archive instead of the installed output.
- Failing to test after rollback.

NEXT: Learn the most common reason a bake succeeds but the game does not change.

8. Fix a Successful Bake That Changed Nothing

BEGINNER	Trace a missing result without rebaking random folders.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The game launches.
- CakeView reported success.
- You know the exact feature that should have changed.

STEPS

1. Confirm the mod is for WWE 2K26 and the current game update.
2. Confirm CakeView is pointed at the correct game executable and target.
3. Open the staging folder and verify it contains the expected path, filenames, and extension types.
4. Check whether the package expected CakeHook, Tribute data, a finished CAK, loose folders, or more than one bake.
5. Confirm the baked output exists and its timestamp changed.
6. Check that the active loader folder is the same one used by the current CakeHook setup.
7. Remove older duplicate copies that could be loading first.
8. Rebuild from the last known-good staging folder and bake once.
9. Test the exact changed feature again.

EXPECTED RESULT: Either the mod appears, or you have isolated the failure to the package structure, target, registration, or loader path.

STOP IF: Stop if fixing the issue would require guessing unknown IDs, hashes, binary fields, or package destinations.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the clean staging folder and loader files before trying a different installation path.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Repeatedly pressing Bake without changing the diagnosis.
- Assuming a character folder alone registers a new slot.
- Leaving two versions of the same package in different loader locations.

NEXT: Move to texture replacement, the safest creation path that changes game assets.

PART 3

Texture Mods

Change artwork while preserving the working geometry, slot, and package structure.

9. Replace One Color Texture

BEGINNER / INTERMEDIATE	Change one visible texture while leaving models and registration untouched.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The target character or item already loads correctly.
- You have the exact stock DDS and a working copy.
- You know the correct filename and folder path.

STEPS

1. Create a texture-only Aurora Forge project.
2. Store the untouched stock DDS in 01_original_extracted_READ_ONLY.
3. Inspect the stock width, height, format, mip count, alpha, and orientation.
4. Export or open a working PNG/TIFF copy without changing the canvas size.
5. Make one visible color change.
6. Preserve transparent padding, edge pixels, and UV orientation.
7. Convert the working image back to DDS using a preset verified for this exact asset family.
8. Name the DDS exactly like the stock file.
9. Place only the changed DDS in a clean staging folder that reproduces the stock path.
10. Compare the original and modified folders. Only the intended DDS should differ.
11. Bake and test the exact surface in more than one lighting condition.

EXPECTED RESULT: The intended color change appears with no new seams, transparency errors, or unrelated package changes.

STOP IF: Stop if the modified folder also changes MCD, MTLS, JMTL, YCL, slot data, or unexpected textures.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the stock DDS or the previous known-good texture build.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Correct dimensions but the wrong UV layout.
- A white or black halo around transparent edges.
- The game brightens or darkens the texture compared with the editor.
- The wrong duplicate texture path was edited.

NEXT: Learn how to compare and prepare DDS files before changing more textures.

10. Prepare and Verify DDS Files

INTERMEDIATE	Match the stock DDS contract instead of relying on one universal export preset.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have the stock DDS and the final working image.
- You can inspect dimensions, format, alpha, and mipmaps.
- The target filename is known.

STEPS

1. Inspect the stock DDS metadata.
2. Record width, height, compression format, mip count, alpha use, and apparent normal-map convention when relevant.
3. Export the authored image at the exact stock dimensions.
4. Convert one test DDS using the target-specific preset.
5. Reopen the test DDS and confirm its metadata.
6. Compare the test visually with the source image for color shifts, alpha damage, or flipped orientation.
7. Keep color, normal, and packed-mask presets separate.
8. Generate mipmaps only when the target and tested workflow require them.
9. Save the working conversion settings with the project, not as a universal WWE 2K26 rule.
10. Bake one DDS and inspect it in game before converting a whole batch.

EXPECTED RESULT: The modified DDS matches the target size and tested metadata, and it survives one in-game test.

STOP IF: Stop if you cannot identify whether a texture is color, normal, alpha-driven, or channel-packed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Delete the unverified converted files and return to the final working PNG/TIFF plus the stock metadata.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Using the face preset for a mask or material map.
- Flipping every texture automatically.
- Destroying alpha during conversion.
- Assuming BC7 alone guarantees compatibility.

NEXT: Apply the texture loop to a face texture and use an in-game calibration pass.

11. Build and Calibrate a Face Texture

INTERMEDIATE	Create a face texture that follows a verified target profile and real in-game UV placement.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have clear front and side references.
- You selected the exact Aurora Forge face profile.
- You have the verified stock/default head texture for that profile.

STEPS

1. Open Face Texture Studio and select the exact target profile.
2. Load the stock head color texture or verified profile authority.
3. Add front and side references with neutral lighting when possible.
4. Define skin tone, age, eyebrows, hairline, facial hair, scars, makeup, and other requested features.
5. Generate or author the texture without baked portrait lighting.
6. Compare eyes, lips, nostrils, ears, jaw, hairline, and neck against the real target layout.
7. Open Face Calibration and mark only the regions that are visibly misplaced.
8. Correct one region at a time.
9. Export at the target size and convert to a tested DDS format.
10. Bake and test under at least two lighting conditions.
11. Repeat calibration only from the last known-good face build.

EXPECTED RESULT: The face reads correctly in normal gameplay, matches the body tone, and has no obvious eye, lip, ear, hairline, jaw, or neck seam errors.

STOP IF: Stop if the target profile is uncertain, the stock footprint is missing, or the result resembles a portrait pasted onto the UV.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the last known-good head texture and keep calibration notes for the next single-region correction.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Baked shadows and highlights.
- Eyes or lips look doubled.
- Neck padding was removed.
- Facial-hair opacity is too solid or too faint.
- The 3D head morph is being blamed on the texture.

NEXT: Use the same profile-first approach for body textures and tattoos.

12. Add Body Textures and Tattoos

INTERMEDIATE	Place readable artwork on the correct body profile without skin mockups or edge halos.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have the verified body texture/profile.
- The artwork is legal to use.
- You know the target body region and side.

STEPS

1. Open Tattoo Studio and select the exact body profile.
2. Choose the target body region and side.
3. Prepare the tattoo artwork on a transparent background.
4. Remove skin, poster backgrounds, and white halos from the artwork.
5. Keep line weight and contrast strong enough for gameplay distance and DDS compression.
6. Use a placement reference to align the art to the real target footprint.
7. Composite the artwork onto a working copy of the body texture.
8. Create the required tattoo support files when the target workflow expects them.
9. Convert the complete set using the target-tested settings.
10. Bake and test front, side, rear, flexed, and moving views.
11. Adjust the flat map, not the in-game screenshot, and retest one change at a time.

EXPECTED RESULT: The tattoo follows the intended body region, remains readable in motion, and has clean alpha edges with no visible seam or halo.

STOP IF: Stop if the body profile, left/right orientation, or required support-file set is uncertain.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous body texture and tattoo support files as one matched set.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Left and right are reversed on the flat map.
- Artwork crosses a seam without enough padding.
- Micro-detail disappears after conversion.
- The tattoo looks like a sticker because of hard white edges.

NEXT: Build a complete luchador mask texture set from the correct mapping profile.

13. Build a Luchador Mask Texture Set

INTERMEDIATE / ADVANCED	Remap an approved wearable mask design into the exact target mask profile and required file family.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have an approved finished mask design.
- You identified the actual in-game mask item/profile.
- You have the stock mask references and mapping guide for that profile.

STEPS

1. Open Luchador Mask Studio and select the exact mapping profile.
2. Load the stock mask color reference and any verified layout guide.
3. Treat the texture as the target profile behaves in game; do not invent a flat cut-out template when the item is a continuous wrap.
4. Place the front identity in the verified front zone.
5. Keep crown and rear-seam art broad, simple, and tolerant of compression or wrap distortion.
6. Build the complete required output set together: mask_color, mask_mask1, and mask_nrm when the item expects all three.
7. Match each stock DDS format independently. Do not apply a face-texture preset to the mask set.
8. Inspect seams, eye placement, mouth/chin coverage, side panels, crown, and rear boundary.
9. Bake and capture front, left, right, rear, and top views.
10. Correct the flat texture from those views and retest the complete matched set.

EXPECTED RESULT: The finished mask reads as one wearable design from every required view and the three files remain synchronized.

STOP IF: Stop if the item/profile family is unknown, the stock layout is missing, or the generated art is only a concept sheet instead of a mapped texture.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous complete mask_color, mask_mask1, and mask_nrm set together.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Front art lands on a side or rear seam.
- Crown symbols collapse into a ring or horseshoe.
- Only mask_color was updated.
- The mask looks like face paint instead of material wrapped around a hood.

NEXT: Use the same target-first method for logos and gear textures.

14. Create Logos and Gear Textures

INTERMEDIATE	Prepare clean artwork that survives UV wrapping, material lighting, and gameplay distance.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You know the target surface and exact texture footprint.
- The logo or emblem is approved and legally usable.
- You have the stock texture or exported UV reference.

STEPS

1. Open Logo / Emblem Studio or Gear / Attire Studio.
2. Define the target surface, size, safe area, palette, and material intent.
3. Prepare transparent artwork with clean alpha and enough edge padding.
4. Avoid hairline strokes, tiny text, and details that will disappear after compression.
5. Check whether the target mirrors, rotates, stretches, or crosses a seam.
6. Composite the design onto a working copy of the stock texture.
7. Create matching normal or packed material guidance only when the target requires it.
8. Convert one test file and inspect it in game.
9. Check the logo in neutral light, entrance light, and normal match distance.
10. Lock the working preset for that exact asset family.

EXPECTED RESULT: The artwork is readable, correctly oriented, free of halos, and consistent with the target material.

STOP IF: Stop if the real UV or stock texture disagrees with the concept layout.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous texture set and return to the verified UV reference.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Mirrored text.
- Logo crosses a seam.
- Metallic or gloss response hides the color art.
- Transparent edges turn dark or white.

NEXT: Add one prepared attire before attempting full character construction.

PART 4

Attires and Character Parts

Add clothing, renders, hair, and accessories in controlled steps.

15. Add One Prepared Attire

INTERMEDIATE	Register one prepared attire to the intended wrestler and test it before adding anything else.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The prepared attire package is complete.
- You know the wrestler ID or can safely locate the wrestler by name.
- Tribute data and character staging folders are backed up.

STEPS

1. Open Tribute and open Attire Manager.
2. Enter or search for the wrestler ID.
3. Load the attire slots.
4. Confirm the displayed wrestler name before continuing.
5. Choose the next intended unused attire slot.
6. Unlock only the attire record you intend to edit.
7. Enter a simple technical folder/render identifier without unnecessary spaces or special characters.
8. Enter the normal readable name that should appear in the attire menu.
9. Choose the prepared character or attire folder.
10. Choose manual or automatic baking on purpose.
11. Press Add Attire once and wait for the success result.
12. Inspect the generated files before baking.
13. Bake when required and test the exact attire slot in the selection screen and a match.

EXPECTED RESULT: The new attire appears under the correct wrestler and loads in game without missing parts or broken materials.

STOP IF: Stop if the wrong wrestler name appears, the intended slot is already occupied, or a field is unfamiliar and undocumented.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the backed-up Tribute data and character staging folder.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Adding the attire to the wrong wrestler.
- Pressing Add Attire more than once.
- Using a display name where a technical identifier is expected.
- Forgetting to bake the generated data.

NEXT: Choose and verify the attire render without mixing the two naming systems.

16. Choose the Attire Slot and Render

INTERMEDIATE	Connect the correct technical identifier, menu name, folder, and render choice.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Chapter 15 is understood.
- You have a custom render only when the package actually supplies one.
- You recorded the intended attire number.

STEPS

1. Load the wrestler and attire slots again.
2. Confirm the attire number you intend to use.
3. Use a short technical identifier for the folder/render field.
4. Use normal readable text for the attire menu name.
5. Choose the prepared character folder.
6. Select the custom render when a valid render is supplied.
7. Use the default-render option when no custom render is needed.
8. Choose Bake After Add only when it matches the tested workflow.
9. Add the attire once and write down the new attire number.
10. Inspect the generated files and the render path before baking.
11. Test the wrestler selection screen, attire selection screen, match load, and post-match screen.

EXPECTED RESULT: The intended attire and render appear together under the correct wrestler.

STOP IF: Stop if the render belongs to a different wrestler, the technical path contains unexpected characters, or the tool displays a different attire number than planned.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous Tribute data and remove the newly generated attire staging files.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Custom render missing because the default option was selected.
- Wrong portrait attached to the correct attire.
- Correct render but wrong attire menu name.

NEXT: Edit the attire texture while leaving geometry and registration unchanged.

17. Edit Attire Textures

INTERMEDIATE	Change color, logos, fabric detail, normals, or packed masks without changing the attire model.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The attire loads correctly before editing.
- You have the complete stock or prepared texture set.
- You know which file controls the visible surface.

STEPS

1. Copy the working attire texture set into 03_working_textures.
2. Inspect every stock DDS used by the attire.
3. Change one color texture first.
4. Preserve UV orientation, alpha, edge padding, and filename.
5. Convert the one changed texture using its target-tested settings.
6. Stage only that texture and bake.
7. Test the attire in neutral match lighting.
8. Add the normal or packed material mask only after the color test passes.
9. Test fabric shine, metallic response, transparency, and seams in a second arena.
10. Save the working texture set as the new known-good attire build.

EXPECTED RESULT: The attire artwork changes while the model, slot, render, and unrelated materials remain stable.

STOP IF: Stop if the modified folder unexpectedly includes model or material-list files.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous matched attire texture set.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Color change is correct but gloss is wrong.
- Packed channels were painted as a normal color image.
- Transparent fabric becomes solid.
- Only one mip level looks correct.

NEXT: Move into geometry only when a texture edit cannot meet the goal.

18. Fit or Port Attire Geometry

ADVANCED	Adapt an attire model to a compatible 2K26 base while preserving skeleton, hierarchy, weights, and materials.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The texture-only path cannot meet the goal.
- You have permission to modify the source attire.
- Blender, the supported PWM addon, and any required Quick Port version are recorded.
- The untouched source and 2K26 target base are archived separately.

STEPS

1. Import the target 2K26 body/skeleton and the source attire through the supported PWM workflow.
2. Align scale, origin, orientation, and ground level before rigging.
3. Fit the attire without making unplanned destructive changes to the body.
4. Preserve required object names, hierarchy, UVs, and material slots.
5. Transfer or repair weights using the supported workflow.
6. Remove unused or wrong vertex groups only when the procedure clearly identifies them.
7. Correct clipping and deformation manually.
8. Prepare hair, mouth, and animated dependencies separately when present.
9. Clean unused data without deleting required objects.
10. Export through the supported PWM path into a disposable test build.
11. Test extreme poses before adding more attire parts.

EXPECTED RESULT: The attire follows the body in idle and extreme poses with no major spikes, collapsed sections, or missing materials.

STOP IF: Stop if the skeleton family is uncertain, the hierarchy no longer matches the target, or the export requires guessing binary structure.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Discard the disposable export and return to the untouched target base plus the last working Blender file.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Wrong skeleton family.
- Weights copied from an incompatible body.
- Object names or hierarchy changed.
- Attire looks fine in Blender but fails in motion.

NEXT: Treat hair, facial hair, and accessories as separate special-case parts.

19. Add Hair, Facial Hair, and Accessories

ADVANCED	Prepare alpha-driven and animated parts without assuming they behave like normal clothing.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The base character and attire work before these parts are added.
- You extracted the related mesh, textures, materials, and companion files.
- You have a separate rollback point.

STEPS

1. Import the target head/body and the hair, facial-hair, or accessory part.
2. Preserve transforms, attachment, weights, hierarchy, and material order.
3. Inspect alpha, two-sided behavior, blend settings, normals, and texture links.
4. Use hair-specific alignment or skeleton tools only when the current supported workflow requires them.
5. Check the hairline, ears, shoulders, entrance clothing, and head movement.
6. Prepare mouth, teeth, and facial animation parts separately from hair.
7. Export one special-case part at a time.
8. Test idle, entrance, running, grappling, and victory motion.
9. Accept that some hair clipping may require manual modeling or may remain a current tool limitation.

EXPECTED RESULT: The part appears with correct transparency and stays acceptably attached through normal animation.

STOP IF: Stop if hair cards render black, disappear, attach to the wrong skeleton, or require destructive changes to a working face package.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Remove the new part and restore the character build that worked before it was added.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Black hair cards from alpha/material mismatch.
- Hair disappears from one viewing side.
- Facial hair uses the wrong texture or shader link.
- Entrance gear intersects long hair.

NEXT: Diagnose clothing and accessory clipping with controlled pose tests.

20. Fix Clipping and Deformation

ADVANCED	Identify whether a problem comes from fit, weights, body shape, collision, material, or animation.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have a clear before/after test.
- Only one new part or subsystem changed.
- The original source and target base are available for comparison.

STEPS

1. Reproduce the defect in the same animation or pose.
2. Decide whether the issue is static fit, motion-only clipping, spikes/stretching, transparency, or championship interaction.
3. For static clipping, correct the mesh fit before changing weights.
4. For motion-only clipping, compare weights and vertex groups with the known-good target part.
5. For spikes or stretching, inspect wrong groups, missing weights, transforms, and skeleton mismatch.
6. For championship clipping, test title entrances, title matches, and victory scenes before changing the body broadly.
7. For black or invisible surfaces, compare material names, shaders, texture links, alpha, and normals with a known-good 2K26 part.
8. Change one cause at a time and export to a new disposable build.
9. Retest the exact failing pose plus one unrelated pose.

EXPECTED RESULT: The defect is either corrected or isolated to a specific system without damaging the rest of the character.

STOP IF: Stop if several systems were changed at once and the original cause can no longer be identified.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the last known-good mesh and material set, then repeat with a smaller change.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Scaling the whole body to hide one clothing problem.
- Changing shaders to fix a weight issue.
- Testing only an idle pose.
- Ignoring belt, rope, and entrance interactions.

NEXT: Use these smaller skills to build a complete character package.

PART 5

Complete Characters

Combine face, body, attire, hair, materials, slots, audio, and presentation without losing the working base.

21. Plan the Character Before Touching Files

ADVANCED	Create one specification that keeps every asset and presentation choice consistent.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have chosen the file-level PC mod path rather than the official CAW path.
- The project has a legal and practical source strategy.
- You are prepared to test the character in stages.

STEPS

1. Open Complete Character in Aurora Forge.
2. Record the ring name, height, body type, face, skin, hair, facial hair, tattoos, ring attire, entrance attire, colors, materials, logos, and emblems.
3. Record championship interaction needs, entrance style, victory style, theme music, announcer call, and GFX concept.
4. Choose the number of attires.
5. Decide whether the project is original, private likeness work, permitted public work, a legal port, or a conversion of your own CAW concept.
6. Record the intended base model and slot strategy.
7. List every asset whose permission or redistribution status must be checked.
8. Save the project before opening external tools.

EXPECTED RESULT: The project can be understood from one page and every asset has a clear purpose, source, and target.

STOP IF: Stop if the public package depends on models, textures, logos, music, likenesses, or video that cannot be redistributed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Return the project to planning status and remove unapproved source assets.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Building parts before agreeing on the palette and materials.
- Using a base only because it has a convenient slot.
- Forgetting championship and entrance interactions.

NEXT: Choose a compatible base, target slot, and complete known-good package.

22. Choose and Archive the Base

ADVANCED	Separate the geometry/material base from the game registration target and preserve the complete working package.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The character specification is complete.
- You can identify a compatible 2K26 base.
- You have CakeView file exploration and Tribute when a new slot is needed.

STEPS

1. Choose a geometry/material base with compatible scale, proportions, head/neck seam, skeleton family, attire complexity, hair needs, material count, and championship behavior.
2. Choose the registration target separately: an existing replacement slot or a supported additional slot.
3. Record the base character ID, target slot, attire slots, music slot, announcer slot, entrance, victory, and render assets.
4. Use CakeView to locate the complete base package.
5. Extract the base model, attire, material lists, material definitions, textures, YCL companions, hair, facial hair, and other related folders.
6. Preserve exact names and folder structure.
7. Hash or otherwise record the untouched files.
8. Copy the full package into 01_original_extracted_READ_ONLY.
9. Launch an unchanged copy as the first test build.

EXPECTED RESULT: The unchanged extracted base loads correctly and every future build can be compared with it.

STOP IF: Stop if only part of the base package was extracted or the chosen base fails before modification.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Re-extract the full known-good package and discard incomplete copies.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Confusing the base model with the target slot.
- Extracting only textures.
- Using an incompatible skeleton family.
- Renaming folders before the unchanged test.

NEXT: Build the asset package in the safest order.

23. Build the Character Asset Package

ADVANCED	Add face, body, attire, hair, logos, normals, and masks in a controlled order.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The unchanged base loads.
- Parts 3 and 4 are understood.
- Each asset has its own working folder and rollback point.

STEPS

1. Build and test the face color texture first.
2. Add body color and tattoos after the face passes.
3. Add the required normal and packed material textures as matched sets.
4. Build one ring attire and test it before adding more clothing.
5. Add hair and facial hair as separate special-case tests.
6. Add logos and emblems after the underlying materials are stable.
7. Add entrance gear only after ring attire works through normal motion.
8. Inspect every final DDS against its stock authority.
9. Inspect model hierarchy, weights, UVs, normals, and material links before export.
10. Compare the completed working package with the original and explain every changed file.

EXPECTED RESULT: The full visual character loads as a replacement build before any new-slot, music, announcer, or GFX work is added.

STOP IF: Stop if the character cannot pass a normal match as a replacement build.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Remove the most recently added subsystem and return to the previous passing build.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Registering a new slot before the package works.
- Adding all attires before one attire is proven.
- Changing material lists to fix a texture-layout problem.

NEXT: Register the stable package and additional attires in Tribute.

24. Register the Character and Attires

ADVANCED	Create or target the intended slot and connect the stable character package without inventing unknown values.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The visual package works as a replacement test.
- Tribute data is backed up.
- You have the current profile or known-good base values required by the tool.

STEPS

1. Open the current Tribute character creation or roster workflow.
2. Select the intended supported new or replacement slot.
3. Load the correct profile or known-good base data when the workflow requires it.
4. Enter the minimum identity fields and save once.
5. Record the wrestler ID and every generated staging location.
6. Attach the prepared character folder.
7. Add the first attire and confirm its number.
8. Add each additional attire one at a time, testing before the next.
9. Choose Auto-Bake or manual bake deliberately.
10. Inspect generated data before baking.
11. Launch the game and verify roster entry, render, attire menu, match load, and basic entrance.

EXPECTED RESULT: The character appears in the intended slot with the correct first attire and no duplicate or overwritten record.

STOP IF: Stop if the tool displays the wrong wrestler, target, ID, attire count, or generated path.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the Tribute backup and remove the newly generated character staging data.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Using a profile for a different character.
- Guessing IDs or hashes.
- Adding several attires before testing the slot.
- Confusing a folder name with the visible wrestler name.

NEXT: Bake the full package and run a complete acceptance test before release.

25. Bake and Run the Full Character Acceptance Test

ADVANCED	Prove the complete character works in menus, matches, entrances, victories, and championship scenes.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The visual package and registration both pass separate tests.
- Music, announcer, and GFX may still be absent; those are added in Part 6.
- The last known-good staging folder is preserved.

STEPS

1. Inspect the final staging folder and confirm every change is expected.
2. Bake once and save the log.
3. Confirm the roster entry and render.
4. Load every attire from the selection screen.
5. Run a normal one-on-one match.
6. Check idle, running, grappling, top-rope, rope, ground, and victory motion.
7. Check face, eyes, mouth, teeth, hair, skin tone, tattoos, clothing, transparency, and materials.
8. Run an entrance with ring and entrance attire transitions.
9. Run a championship entrance, title match, and title victory scene when relevant.
10. Check at least two arenas and lighting conditions.
11. Record defects by subsystem and fix only one subsystem per new build.

EXPECTED RESULT: The complete character is stable enough to proceed to audio and presentation or to remain as a working visual mod.

STOP IF: Stop release if any attire crashes, the character is invisible, animations deform badly, or rollback has not been tested.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the last known-good staging folder and Tribute data, then remove the newest subsystem.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Testing only the default attire.
- Ignoring title scenes.
- Calling a successful bake a successful character.
- Releasing without a clean uninstall path.

NEXT: Add theme music as a separate, reversible project.

PART 6

Audio and Presentation

Add theme music, announcer calls, GFX, and video only after the character itself is stable.

26. Add Theme Music

INTERMEDIATE / ADVANCED	Import or replace one legal theme track and connect its ID to the intended character.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The character slot works.
- The current compatible audio workflow and tool documentation are available.
- You have legal permission to use the audio.
- Audio databases and staging data are backed up.

STEPS

1. Prepare a clean audio file with controlled level, start, and ending.
2. Open the current supported audio tool and configure any required Wwise or database paths.
3. Choose add or replace according to the tool and project plan.
4. Import the theme and wait for the success result.
5. Write down the music ID immediately.
6. Reopen or preview the imported record when the tool supports it.
7. Open Tribute and connect the recorded music ID to the correct character.
8. Inspect the generated data before baking.
9. Bake and test the entrance, victory, and any menu preview that uses the track.
10. Check volume, start timing, loop or ending, and whether the track belongs to the correct character.

EXPECTED RESULT: The intended theme plays for the intended character without breaking unrelated audio.

STOP IF: Stop if the audio tool version, target database, codec, or add-versus-replace behavior is uncertain.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the backed-up audio database and character registration data.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Music ID copied incorrectly.
- Track replaces unrelated audio.
- Volume clips or is much quieter than game audio.
- Entrance starts before the usable part of the song.

NEXT: Add ring-announcer audio as a separate ID and test.

27. Add Ring-Announcer Audio

INTERMEDIATE / ADVANCED	Import or assign one announcer call and connect it to the correct character.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The character ID is known.
- The current audio workflow is verified.
- The audio is legally usable and clearly labeled.

STEPS

1. Prepare the announcer call with clean speech, minimal noise, and appropriate level.
2. Import or replace it using the current supported audio tool.
3. Record the announcer ID.
4. Reopen or preview the record when possible.
5. Open Tribute and select the correct character.
6. Assign the announcer ID once.
7. Inspect the generated data before baking.
8. Bake and test the ring introduction in a normal match.
9. Test a title match or alternate context when the character will use one.
10. Confirm the call does not point to another wrestler and the name is intelligible in arena ambience.

EXPECTED RESULT: The correct announcer call plays for the correct character in the expected match context.

STOP IF: Stop if the tool cannot prove which record or ID is being changed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous audio database and roster/character data.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Theme music ID entered in the announcer field.
- Correct audio but wrong character assignment.
- Call is cut off by timing or too quiet in arena ambience.

NEXT: Add entrance GFX and video after audio IDs are stable.

28. Add Entrance GFX and Video

INTERMEDIATE / ADVANCED	Connect the correct legal media to titantron, banner, apron, and other presentation targets.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The character slot works.
- The GFX package is complete and uses legally usable media.
- You know which screens and target paths the current tool expects.

STEPS

1. Prepare distinct media for each required screen instead of reusing one file blindly.
2. Keep important text and logos inside safe areas.
3. Create smooth loops without obvious flashes or hard cuts.
4. Open Tribute GFX Manager or the current supported presentation workflow.
5. Select the correct character and enter the normal menu name.
6. Use Auto-Assign only when the current tool and package support it.
7. Review every assigned ID, hash, asset row, and expected package path.
8. Add the GFX once and wait for success.
9. Inspect the generated staging files and copy the legal media package into the expected location.
10. Bake and test the entrance from beginning to ring arrival.
11. Check titantron, banner, apron, stage, nameplate, and any other affected display.

EXPECTED RESULT: The correct media appears on the correct screens for the intended character with acceptable timing and brightness.

STOP IF: Stop if the media target, hash, path, or package structure is being guessed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous presentation data and remove the newly staged media package.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Correct video on the wrong screen.
- Black levels do not match the arena.
- Text falls outside safe areas.
- A loop flashes at the cut.

NEXT: Run one complete entrance and presentation acceptance test.

29. Run the Presentation Acceptance Test

INTERMEDIATE / ADVANCED	Test music, announcer, entrance motion, gear, and GFX as one experience.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Chapters 26 through 28 pass separately.
- The character visual package already passed Chapter 25.
- A rollback exists for audio and presentation data.

STEPS

1. Start from the wrestler selection screen and confirm the correct render and attire.
2. Begin a normal entrance.
3. Confirm the announcer call belongs to the character.
4. Confirm the theme starts at the intended time and volume.
5. Check titantron, banner, apron, stage, nameplate, and other media targets.
6. Watch hair, entrance gear, stage props, and character movement through the full entrance.
7. Confirm lighting reveals the face and attire correctly.
8. Confirm entrance attire transitions correctly to ring attire.
9. Run a victory scene and a championship entrance when relevant.
10. Record timing, clipping, wrong media, wrong audio, and brightness issues separately.

EXPECTED RESULT: The entrance, match presentation, and victory presentation identify the correct character and remain stable.

STOP IF: Stop release if audio or media belongs to another character, entrance gear intersects badly, or photosensitive flashing is present.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the last passing audio/presentation backup and re-add one subsystem at a time.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Testing with entrances disabled.
- Ignoring the transition from entrance attire to ring attire.
- Fixing media brightness by changing the character material.

NEXT: Move to arenas and championship belts as separate projects.

PART 7

Arenas and Championship Belts

Install, create, register, and test venue and title packages without mixing asset paths.

30. Install a Ready-Made Arena

INTERMEDIATE	Install one creator-approved arena package using either its finished-CAK path or loose-folder path.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The clean baseline works.
- The package is intended for WWE 2K26.
- CakeView, CakeHook, Tribute arena data, and active BakeMe folders are backed up.
- You have read the package instructions.

STEPS

1. Scan and extract the package into a new project folder.
2. Identify whether the author supplies a finished CAK or loose Arena, Environment, Movies, Props, UI, and related folders.
3. Use only the asset path intended by the author. Do not install both paths.
4. For a finished CAK, place it only where the current package and loader instructions specify.
5. For loose folders, collect them inside one clearly named project folder and bake that folder with CakeView.
6. Copy supplied arena profiles into the current Tribute Arena Profiles location when required.
7. Open the current Tribute arena tool and load one profile.
8. Add one arena slot and wait for success.
9. Open Arena Manager, load the profiles, and inspect the new record.
10. Edit only human-readable names you understand.
11. Generate or save the data, bake when required, and test both an entrance and a normal match.

EXPECTED RESULT: The arena appears in the intended slot with its assets and profile working together.

STOP IF: Stop if the package does not explain whether it uses a finished CAK or loose folders, or if IDs and hashes would have to be invented.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the CakeView, CakeHook, Tribute, and BakeMe backups, then remove the installed arena assets.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Installing both CAK and loose paths.
- Adding several profiles before testing one.
- Arena menu entry exists but assets were never baked.
- Assets load but the wrong profile was registered.

NEXT: Plan a complete arena and ring-branding package before authoring assets.

31. Build an Arena and Ring-Branding Package

ADVANCED Create a consistent venue identity and all required visual assets before registration.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You chose the official Create-An-Arena path or an extended PC path.
- The show identity and legal asset sources are approved.
- You know which surfaces and media the target workflow uses.

STEPS

1. Open Arena / Ring Branding Studio.
2. Define the show name, era, venue size, palette, logo, lighting intent, and audience scale.
3. Plan ring apron, mat, turnbuckle, barricade, stage, ramp, walls, screens, signage, thumbnails, locators, nameplates, results, and other show assets.
4. Create a safe-area guide for every screen that contains text or a logo.
5. Prepare color, normal, transparency, and material intent for each physical surface.
6. Build official Create-An-Arena assets inside the game when the official path is sufficient.
7. Use Arena Builder only for supported placement beyond normal restrictions.
8. Keep arena geometry, show media, profiles, and Tribute data in separate subfolders.
9. Preview every asset at gameplay distance and under the intended lighting.
10. Create one project checklist naming every required file and its target.

EXPECTED RESULT: The arena has one consistent identity and every visual has a known target before game registration begins.

STOP IF: Stop if the project is mixing official and extended paths without a clear plan or if required target sizes and paths are unknown.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Return to the approved arena plan and remove unverified assets from the build folder.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Designing only the ring while ignoring stage and presentation screens.
- Tiny text outside screen safe areas.
- Building placement before the visual package is approved.

NEXT: Register, bake, and test the arena in entrance and match conditions.

32. Register and Test the Arena

ADVANCED	Connect arena assets, profiles, placement data, and menu records, then test gameplay and entrances.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The arena asset package is complete.
- The intended arena profile and slot plan are recorded.
- All current arena and Tribute data are backed up.

STEPS

1. Place or bake the arena assets using the correct finished-CAK or loose-folder path.
2. Load the intended arena profile in Tribute.
3. Add one arena slot and record the result.
4. Open Arena Manager and verify the new profile.
5. Edit only documented, human-readable values.
6. Import or edit supported prop maps only from a known package and change one documented field at a time.
7. Save changes to a new copy.
8. Bake the arena assets and Tribute data as required.
9. Run a full entrance and check cameras, lighting, screens, props, wrestler movement, and stage clearance.
10. Run a normal match and check ropes, ring visibility, collisions, barricades, crowd, and gameplay readability.
11. Test one unrelated arena to detect broad side effects.

EXPECTED RESULT: The arena menu record, physical venue, presentation assets, and gameplay behavior all match the intended project.

STOP IF: Stop if props obstruct wrestlers, cameras fail, IDs or coordinates are guessed, or unrelated arenas change.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the arena profile, prop-map, Tribute, and staging backups.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Entrance works but gameplay has collisions.
- Arena record exists with missing assets.
- Prop changes affect more objects than intended.
- Lighting makes logos unreadable.

NEXT: Create or install a championship belt and test it in motion and title scenes.

33. Install or Create a Championship Belt

ADVANCED	Build or port a belt package and test geometry, materials, straps, entrances, matches, and victory scenes.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The belt source is legal to use.
- You know the target belt ID/folder strategy.
- The original belt package and title data are backed up.

STEPS

1. Open Championship Belt Studio and define plate layout, strap shape, palette, materials, logos, and side-plate needs.
2. Prepare the color, normal, and packed material textures from a verified target layout.
3. For a model replacement or port, preserve scale, hierarchy, material slots, and the working target package structure.
4. Use the supported model and material conversion workflow.
5. Place the finished model, materials, and textures into a clean staging folder.
6. Register or target the intended belt record only through the supported current workflow.
7. Bake and inspect the belt in menus.
8. Run a title entrance.
9. Run a title match and check carrying, hand placement, waist placement, ropes, and body clipping.
10. Run a victory scene and check plate, strap, and side-plate behavior.

EXPECTED RESULT: The belt looks correct in menus and remains acceptable in title entrance, match, and victory scenes.

STOP IF: Stop if the belt ID, folder, model conversion, or title-scene data must be guessed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the original belt package, textures, and title data.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Belt looks correct in a still preview but clips through the body.
- Metal plate or strap material is too shiny or black.
- Wrong title record or render.

NEXT: Use the advanced porting chapters when adapting WWE 2K25 content.

PART 8

2K25 to 2K26 Ports

Advanced work: version-match the toolchain, preserve the source, and test every subsystem.

34. Prepare a Porting Project

ADVANCED | Create a controlled source-to-target workspace before importing any 2K25 model or arena.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You have permission to modify and use the source assets.
- You have a compatible 2K26 target base.
- The supported Blender, PWM addon, Quick Port, CakeView, and Tribute versions are recorded.

STEPS

1. Create separate Source_2K25, Target_2K26, Blender_Work, Converted_Materials, Staging, and Test_Builds folders.
2. Archive the untouched 2K25 package and the untouched 2K26 base.
3. Record source and target skeleton families.
4. Record model, attire, hair, mouth, teeth, material, YCL, texture, and registration dependencies.
5. Decide whether the project is a simple file conversion or a full rebuild on the 2K26 base.
6. Choose one documented porting path. Do not mix steps from different tutorials casually.
7. Create a disposable first build and a written acceptance checklist.
8. Confirm the unchanged 2K26 target base loads before import.

EXPECTED RESULT: The port has a known source, compatible target, fixed toolchain, chosen method, and disposable test path.

STOP IF: Stop if the source rights, target skeleton, or supported tool versions are uncertain.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Delete the disposable working files and return to the untouched source and target archives.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Starting with the source model but no compatible 2K26 base.
- Updating Blender or the addon halfway through the port.
- Combining a short conversion path with a full rebuild path.

NEXT: Port the base wrestler or one attire before attempting hair and presentation.

35. Port a Wrestler or Attire

ADVANCED	Move a 2K25 model onto a working 2K26 base and produce a disposable in-game test.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Chapter 34 is complete.
- The target skeleton family matches the source category.
- The 2K26 base works unchanged.

STEPS

1. Import the source and target using the supported PWM workflow.
2. Align scale, origin, orientation, and ground level.
3. Prepare or combine skeleton relationships exactly as the chosen workflow requires.
4. Match required hierarchy and object names.
5. Transfer or repair weights.
6. Prepare the mouth, eyes, teeth, and mouth bag when porting a full wrestler.
7. Validate UVs, normals, and material slots.
8. Convert or save material and YCL-related data through the supported current tools.
9. Export or inject into a disposable build.
10. Map the build to the target package, bake, and test before adding extra attire or hair.
11. For attire, test extreme poses and compare deformation with the original source.

EXPECTED RESULT: The base port loads in 2K26 and can complete a basic match without catastrophic deformation or missing surfaces.

STOP IF: Stop if mouth parts, skeleton hierarchy, weights, or required material data are missing.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Discard the disposable build and reopen the last working Blender file based on the untouched target.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Wrong skeleton category for female, giant, or normal-male characters.
- Removing all vertex groups instead of only identified groups.
- Port looks correct in Blender but the mouth or eyes fail in game.

NEXT: Repair skeletons, weights, mouth parts, hair, and animated materials as separate problems.

36. Repair Skeletons, Weights, Mouth, and Hair

ADVANCED Correct the special systems that most often break a character port.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The base port reaches the game.
- You can reproduce one specific deformation or missing-part problem.
- The original source and target weights are available for comparison.

STEPS

1. For spikes or stretching, identify the exact mesh and pose that fail.
2. Compare its vertex groups and weights with the original source and compatible 2K26 target.
3. Remove old groups only from parts the chosen workflow identifies.
4. Run the supported rigging or weight-transfer operation.
5. Inspect mouth bags, teeth, eyes, and facial parts as separate objects with correct armature relationships.
6. Treat hair and animated materials as special cases.
7. Use hair-only alignment or skeleton functions only when the current workflow calls for them.
8. Check alpha, two-sided behavior, material order, and YCL dependencies.
9. Export one repaired subsystem to a new test build.
10. Test extreme poses, face motion, entrance motion, and hair clipping.

EXPECTED RESULT: The repaired subsystem improves without breaking the already working body, face, attire, or materials.

STOP IF: Stop if the repair requires deleting unknown groups, changing the whole skeleton, or copying values from an unrelated character.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the previous Blender file and disposable build, then isolate a smaller subsystem.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Mouth and teeth attached to the wrong armature.
- Weights transferred from an incompatible body shape.
- Hair clipping remains after the main mask or attire problem is fixed.
- YCL-related behavior differs between tool versions.

NEXT: Port arena, show, or belt assets only after understanding their complete dependency chain.

37. Port Arenas, Show Assets, and Belts

ADVANCED	Convert older venue and title packages while preserving model, light, material, profile, and presentation dependencies.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The source package is legally usable.
- You have a working 2K26 target arena or belt family.
- Arena, Environment, Movies, UI, model, light, material, texture, and profile folders are inventoried.

STEPS

1. Choose a compatible 2K26 target package and preserve it unchanged.
2. Inventory every 2K25 model, light, material, texture, movie, UI, and profile dependency.
3. Convert model and material data using the supported current workflow.
4. Preserve or rebuild folder relationships under the 2K26 target structure.
5. Convert show logos, thumbnails, locators, matchup screens, nameplates, result graphics, fonts, and movies separately from physical arena geometry.
6. For belts, preserve the target ID/folder strategy, model, materials, textures, and title-scene behavior.
7. Bake physical assets and registration data through their correct separate paths.
8. Test an entrance, normal match, and all affected presentation screens.
9. For belts, test title entrance, carrying, waist placement, match interaction, and victory scene.
10. Compare one unrelated arena or belt after the port.

EXPECTED RESULT: The converted package works in its intended 2K26 target without changing unrelated content.

STOP IF: Stop if Preload/Def relationships, profile values, light/material links, or target IDs must be guessed.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the untouched 2K26 target and remove the converted physical and registration assets together.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Physical arena loads but show UI is missing.
- UI works but models or lights are absent.
- Belt preview works but title scenes clip badly.

NEXT: Run the complete port acceptance test and do not call a bake a finished port.

38. Run the Complete Port Acceptance Test

ADVANCED Prove the port across appearance, animation, entrances, championships, arenas, and rollback.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- The port reaches the game.
- Every added subsystem has a separate test history.
- The untouched target and last known-good build are preserved.

STEPS

1. Record the final game, Blender, PWM, Quick Port, CakeView, CakeHook, and Tribute versions.
2. Inspect the final changed-file list.
3. Confirm the correct target slot, arena, attire, or belt record.
4. Run a normal match and test extreme poses.
5. Check face motion, mouth, eyes, teeth, hair, attire, materials, alpha, and textures.
6. Run entrances, victories, and title scenes when relevant.
7. Test every added attire.
8. Test in at least two arenas or lighting conditions.
9. Test one unrelated character, arena, or belt.
10. Remove the port and prove that rollback restores the previous state.
11. Package only the files and instructions required for the legal intended release.

EXPECTED RESULT: The port is reproducible, removable, and stable across the scenes it is intended to support.

STOP IF: Stop release if any required subsystem is untested, the build cannot be removed cleanly, or the package depends on unverified tool behavior.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: Restore the complete previous target package, registration data, and loader staging folders.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Only testing the default attire.
- Ignoring hair and mouth because the model loads.
- Releasing a tool-version-sensitive port without recording versions.

NEXT: Use the troubleshooting part whenever a visible symptom appears.

PART 9

Troubleshooting

Start with what you can see, then change one likely cause at a time.

39. Diagnose by Symptom

ALL LEVELS Use the smallest test that separates path, registration, texture, material, geometry, audio, and presentation failures.

FIRST MOVE: Return to the last known-good build. Reproduce the problem once. Write down exactly what is wrong before changing anything.

Symptom	Likely area	First controlled test
The mod does not appear	Wrong target, wrong folder level, missing registration, inactive loader path, duplicate older package.	Confirm game/target; inspect staging path; verify baked output timestamp; check required Tribute/CAK/loose-folder step; remove duplicates; rebake once.
The game crashes	Broken package structure, incompatible tool/game version, missing dependency, invalid model/material export.	Test clean game; disable newest project; restore loader backup; compare changed files; re-add the smallest known-good mod.
Character is invisible or black	Missing texture, wrong material/shader link, wrong material name, alpha/normal issue, missing mesh.	Compare head, body, eyes, eyelashes, teeth, and mouth-bag rows with a known-good 2K26 base; verify every referenced texture exists; change one wrong row.
Texture is scrambled or misplaced	Correct dimensions but wrong UV/profile, mirrored orientation, wrong asset family, wrong duplicate path.	Reopen the stock DDS and real target profile; compare landmarks; verify filename/path; restore stock and test one marked grid or landmark.
Material is too shiny, flat, or dark	Wrong packed channels, shader/material mismatch, wrong color space or normal convention.	Restore stock packed mask; add one channel at a time; compare with known-good material; test in two arenas.
Mesh spikes or stretches	Wrong weights, vertex groups, transforms, skeleton family, or hierarchy.	Reproduce exact pose; compare groups/weights to source and target; repair one mesh; export to disposable build.
Hair is black, missing, or clipping	Alpha/two-sided/material issue, wrong attachment or weight, current tool limitation.	Check alpha, texture link, normals, material order, skeleton attachment; test without entrance gear; compare side views.
Audio does not play or plays for the wrong wrestler	Wrong ID, wrong database, failed import, add/replace mismatch, registration not baked.	Preview imported record; verify written ID; inspect Tribute assignment; restore database backup; import one test clip.
GFX appears on the wrong screen	Wrong assigned row/hash/path, reused media, package structure mismatch.	Review every GFX row and expected path; use distinct test media; add once; inspect generated data before bake.
Arena is missing parts or behaves badly	Assets and profile not both installed, wrong path, missing props/lights/materials, unsafe prop edit.	Separate physical assets from Tribute profile; verify each bake; restore prop maps; test entrance and match independently.
Championship clips through a character	Body/attire proportions, belt geometry, pose interaction, title-scene limitations.	Test title entrance, carrying, waist placement, match and victory; isolate character versus belt; avoid broad body changes for one scene.

THE DIAGNOSTIC ORDER

1. Confirm the clean game still works.
2. Disable the newest project and confirm the problem disappears.

3. Restore the last known-good build.
4. Compare original and modified folders.
5. Identify whether the failure is path, registration, texture, material, geometry, audio, or presentation.
6. Change one likely cause.
7. Bake once and repeat the same test.
8. Keep the change only when the exact symptom improves and unrelated features still work.

DO NOT GUESS: Unknown IDs, hashes, binary fields, skeleton operations, and package destinations are stop conditions. Find a verified current procedure or restore the working build.

40. Restore the Last Working Build

ALL LEVELS	Return the game and project to a known state without deleting unrelated mods or tool data.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- You know which project introduced the failure.
- The last known-good build and pre-change backups exist.
- The game is closed.

STEPS

1. Copy the failed build and logs into a Failed_Test folder for later diagnosis.
2. Remove only the files introduced by the failed project.
3. Restore the last known-good staging folder.
4. Restore Tribute, audio, arena, or loader data only when the failed project changed it.
5. Restore the matching complete texture or material set rather than one random file.
6. Launch the clean or previous known-good baseline.
7. Repeat the exact test that failed.
8. Confirm one unrelated feature still works.
9. Record the restored version and mark it LAST_KNOWN_GOOD again.
10. Create a new test build before attempting a smaller fix.

EXPECTED RESULT: The project and game have returned to the last verified state and the failed experiment is preserved for comparison.

STOP IF: Stop if the rollback would require deleting shared folders or files whose ownership is uncertain. Restore the complete backup instead.

UNDO / ROLLBACK: This chapter is the rollback. When it fails, restore the full pre-project backup or clean installation and rebuild from documented projects.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Deleting a shared loader folder used by several projects.
- Restoring textures but not matching material or registration data.
- Trying the next fix before proving the rollback worked.

NEXT: Use the appendices as quick references and print the validation checklists for complex projects.

PART A

Appendices

Quick references, folder maps, checklists, and endnotes.

Appendix A - Quick Tool Reference

Tool	Use it for	Do not assume
Aurora Forge	Projects, references, creative studios, handoff packs, validation, inspection guidance	It directly edits every proprietary game format.
CakeView	File exploration, viewing supported assets, baking project folders	A successful bake proves the mod works.
CakeHook	Game-side loading and runtime support	Any similarly named DLL is safe or compatible.
Tribute	Characters, attires, arena records, music/announcer IDs, GFX, Auto-Bake workflows	Every ID, hash, menu, or checkbox is universal across versions.
Blender + PWM	Geometry, skeleton, weights, hierarchy, mouth, hair, attire import/export	A good Blender preview guarantees good game behavior.
Quick Port	Assists supported Blender/PWM porting tasks	It is a one-click replacement for manual cleanup.
DDS tool / texconv	Inspecting, converting, compressing, resizing, and generating mipmaps	One preset fits every texture family.
Audio tool	Importing or replacing legal theme and announcer audio	The current database, codec, and add/replace behavior never change.
Arena Builder	Supported arena placement beyond normal in-game restrictions	It replaces arena assets, profiles, and testing.

Appendix B - Plain-English File Glossary

Term	Plain-English meaning
Bake	Package a prepared staging folder so the current loader/toolchain can use it.
BakeMe	A staging folder used by some workflows. It is not a universal package standard.
CAK	A packaged game/mod archive used by the loader and baking ecosystem.
DDS	The game texture file. It can contain color, alpha, normals, or packed material channels.
MCD	A game model/container file used in character and asset workflows. Treat it with supported tools.
MTLS	A material-list or material-link part of the game asset chain.
JMTL	A material-definition part of the game asset chain.
YCL	A companion file used by some character, attire, hair, or animated-material workflows.
OBJ	A common exported geometry format useful for UV and mesh inspection; it does not preserve every game-specific feature.
UV	The map that tells a 3D model where each part of a flat texture appears.
Normal map	A texture that changes the way small surface depth reacts to light.
Packed mask	One texture whose color channels control different material properties.
Alpha	Transparency information stored in or beside a texture.
Slot	A game record that identifies a character, attire, arena, music item, announcer item, or belt.
Profile	A saved set of target-specific layout or registration information. Use only the correct profile.
Known-good build	A project version that passed the exact in-game test and can be restored.

Appendix C - Folder Maps

MAIN MODDING WORKSPACE

```
WWE2K26_Modding/
  Apps/
  Projects/
  Downloads_Quarantine/
  Tool_Archives/
  Documentation/
```

PROJECT FOLDER

```
Project_Name/
  00_source_notes/
  01_original_extracted_READ_ONLY/
  02_aurora_handoff/
  03_working_textures/
  04_working_models/
  05_working_audio_video/
  06_bakeme_staging/
  07_test_builds/
  08_release/
  09_screenshots_and_logs/
```

PORTING PROJECT

```
Port_Project/
  Source_2K25_READ_ONLY/
  Target_2K26_READ_ONLY/
  Blender_Work/
  Converted_Materials/
  Staging/
  Test_Builds/
  Screenshots_Logs/
```

Appendix D - Printable Validation Checklists

Every project

- [ ] Game launches without the new project.
- [ ] Tool and game versions recorded.
- [ ] Untouched source archived.
- [ ] Last known-good build identified.
- [ ] Only intended files changed.
- [ ] Rollback tested.

Texture pre-bake

- [ ] Correct target profile and stock authority.
- [ ] Width and height match target.
- [ ] Filename and path match target.
- [ ] Alpha preserved.
- [ ] Format and mip behavior checked.
- [ ] No unexpected model or registration changes.

Model pre-bake

- [ ] Correct skeleton family.
- [ ] Scale, origin, and orientation checked.
- [ ] Required hierarchy and names preserved.
- [ ] Weights and vertex groups reviewed.
- [ ] UVs, normals, and material slots checked.
- [ ] Extreme-pose test planned.

Character registration

- [ ] Correct wrestler and target slot.
- [ ] Wrestler ID recorded.
- [ ] Attire slots recorded.
- [ ] Music and announcer IDs recorded.
- [ ] Render and GFX targets recorded.
- [ ] Tribute backup exists.

Arena preflight

- [ ] Correct CAK or loose-folder path chosen.
- [ ] Arena assets and profile both prepared.
- [ ] Human-readable names checked.
- [ ] Props, cameras, lighting, collisions, and screens tested.
- [ ] Entrance and normal match tested.
- [ ] Unrelated arena tested.

Final release

- [ ] All intended scenes tested.
- [ ] Install instructions written.
- [ ] Uninstall/rollback instructions written.
- [ ] Required tool versions listed.
- [ ] Only redistributable files included.
- [ ] Archive scanned and reopened.

Appendix E - Endnotes and Version Notes

The reader handbook intentionally removes source-by-source commentary from the lessons. These notes identify the main documentation families used by the original Aurora Forge research archive. Tool behavior can change after game or application updates; always use the documentation for the versions actually installed.

1. Pro Wrestling Mods, "CakeView 26 & CakeHook," April 28, 2026. Vendor information for CakeView exploration/baking and the CakeHook installation target.
2. Tribute Modding, "TRIBUTE 26 IS HERE!," April 18, 2026. Vendor information for character and attire capacity, music/announcer slots, required tools, and Auto-Bake.
3. Vynx.dev, "2K26 Quick Port." Workflow documentation explaining that Quick Port uses the supported PWM Blender workflow and does not guarantee a one-click port.
4. Vynx.dev, "Arena Builder." Current documentation for supported extended arena-placement work.
5. Microsoft DirectXTex, "Texconv." Documentation for DDS inspection, conversion, compression, mipmaps, resizing, recursion, and related command-line operations.
6. Blender Foundation, Wavefront OBJ and glTF documentation. Used for the limits of generic mesh preview and format conversion.
7. WWE 2K Support, WWE 2K26 PC requirements/basic troubleshooting and Image Uploader/Community Creations documentation.
8. Take-Two Interactive Terms of Service and the permissions supplied by individual mod, model, image, audio, and video creators. This handbook is not legal advice.
9. Community tutorials, package instructions, and controlled original-versus-modified comparisons informed several operational workflows. They remain version-sensitive and should not override current vendor documentation.

VERSION NOTE

This reader edition is maintained for Aurora Forge 1.6.0 RC1. Procedures that depend on private, paid, community-hosted, or fast-changing tool screens should be checked against the currently installed tool documentation before use.

AURORA FORGE / VIKINGSTUDIOS

Start small. Keep backups. Change one thing. Test it. Know how to undo it.